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Hybridity and Space in European Colonial Cities in the Indian Ocean Realm*

Nuno Grancho**

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Resumo

As cidades coloniais são híbridos que integram elementos de distintas arquitecturas e urbanismos. Esta hibridização de cultura material manifesta-se de forma particular em antigas urbes coloniais do oceano Índico como Diu, Tranquebar e Zanzibar. O colonialismo produziu arquitecturas, cidades e cultura material hibrídas, cujos desenho, metodologia e processos persistem até hoje como objectos de investigação académica. O hibridismo revela-se com maior propriedade num contexto de declínio ou fraqueza da autoridade imperial europeia. A integração subvalorizada do saber técnico dos construtores locais da arquitectura e das cidades coloniais europeias gerou soluções inovadoras e originais. O presente artigo faz uma análise de Diu, Tranquebar e Zanzibar no período colonial tardio, para contrastar e comparar culturas construtivas distintas na génese de formas espaciais híbridas.

Abstract

Colonial dwellings are hybrids that blend elements from different architectural and urban traditions. This is particularly evident in the Indian Ocean realm, in former colonial cities such as Diu, Tranquebar, and Zanzibar. Colonialism generated mixed architectural practices whose forms and evolution remain under study. In these sites, hybridity becomes especially evident when imperial authority weakens. The overlooked integration of "native" builders' expertise into European colonial construction often produced innovative outcomes. This paper examines Diu (Portuguese), Tranquebar (Danish), and Zanzibar (Portuguese, Omani, British) during the late colonial era to compare how distinct building cultures combined to create hybrid spatial forms.

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Introduction

Across the Indian Ocean, early modern and modern empires shaped urban landscapes through ongoing negotiations between European efforts of authority and the existing spatial, cultural, and economic structures of coastal communities. This paper examines Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar to illustrate how colonial place-making evolved as a relational, contested, and hybrid process. Although influenced by British, Portuguese, and Danish interventions, these cities did not become fixed representations of European spatial ideas. Instead, they demonstrate how architectural forms, urban regulations, and material culture were co-created by imperial powers, local participants, and the patterns of oceanic exchange. These patterns reflect broader circulation routes that connected Africa, Arabia, India, and Europe (Chaudhuri 1983).

The comparative framework used here is deliberate. Each of these cities served as a strategic hub in the Indian Ocean region. They developed under markedly different imperial traditions. They are included because they demonstrate various modes of imperial rule, different relationships between colonizer and colonized, and unique forms of spatial negotiation. These examples also help us understand how a shared ocean environment created distinct power structures that eventually merged into hybrid forms of urban life. The goal is not to suggest that these three cities represent all colonial formations in the Indian Ocean region. Instead, they were selected because their material and political histories highlight key processes often overlooked. These include layered sovereignties, co-created civic cultures, and the unstable spatial outcomes resulting from conflicting imperial interests. Primary sources are used to support the spatial arguments discussed here. These include nineteenth-century travel accounts such as Richard Burton's description of Zanzibar (Burton 1872), imperial administrative correspondence from the British Protectorate period in Zanzibar, letters and reports from the Danish East India Company regarding Tranquebar, and Portuguese, Gujarati, and local petitions related to Diu preserved in the Overseas Historical Archive in Lisbon. These sources enable us to gain

insight into contemporary perspectives on urban space. They also clarify how social processes were reflected in the built environment, especially in areas where colonial rule intersected with local institutions.

The theoretical approach guiding this study engages with postcolonial critiques while recognizing their limitations. The interpretive frameworks introduced by Edward Said's analysis of *Orientalism* emphasize discourse, representation, and colonial knowledge (Said 1978). While these ideas remain valuable, they are not enough to understand urban environments where power was fragmented, limited, or exercised through incomplete bureaucratic systems. In such cases, material practices often diverged from ideological claims, resulting in ways of negotiation that do not fit easily into strict binaries of domination and resistance. Scholars of colonial urbanism in Africa and Asia, including Myers (2003), King (1990), and AlSayyad (2001), have also emphasized the importance of attending to daily practices and spatial arrangements.

The Indian Ocean was not just a passive background for these events. Its monsoon patterns facilitated the movement of people, materials, capital, and ideas. These flows linked Zanzibar to Oman and the Swahili coast, connected Diu to Gujarat and the western Indian Ocean trade network, and tied Tranquebar to both Tamil states and Northern European commercial systems. Such exchanges ensured that architectural styles, urban regulations, and material culture developed through cross-regional interactions rather than solely through European influence. Therefore, understanding these cities requires attention to both local and imperial forces that shaped them, as well as to the oceanic routes that created their hybrid identities.

The following discusses each city individually and then compares them. The analysis goes beyond simple labels like European and indigenous or colonizer and colonized. Instead, it explores how shifting alliances, economic needs, and sociocultural connections created complex and sometimes conflicting urban environments. Using this perspective, Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar stand out as sites of colonial power and urban modernity shaped across different cultures.

Beyond Dualism

Since Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978), scholars have increasingly questioned the stability of categories like "West" and "East," recognizing that Europe and its "others" were co-created through their unequal interactions.

This postcolonial shift has deeply influenced the fields of architectural and urban history. Gwendolyn Wright (1991) and Mia Fuller (2007) have shown how European colonies acted as testing grounds for disciplinary regimes before they were adopted in metropolitan societies. Ann Laura Stoler (1995) uncovered the complex ways race, sexuality, and governance were interconnected across colonial and metropolitan environments.

The past two decades have challenged earlier dualistic views of colonial cities, which depicted them as clearly divided between European and indigenous zones (Lewis 2011). Studies by Swati Chattopadhyay (2005), William Glover (2007), and Jyoti Hosagrahar (2005) have illustrated how colonial urban spaces featured intricate interconnections, contested practices, and hybrid forms that resist simple binaries, such as colonizer/colonized, modern/traditional, or European/native. Anthony King (2003, 381-397) states that hybridity describes a process whereby exchange between two (or more) existing cultures produces new cultural forms and practices.

We build on Homi Bhabha's concept of hybridity while remaining attentive to critiques of this framework. Bhabha (1990, 211) describes a "Third Space" of hybridity that "displaces the histories that constitute it," arguing that all forms of culture are continually in a process of hybridity. However, we must avoid romanticizing hybridity or treating it as inherently progressive. As recent scholarship emphasizes, hybrid forms emerged within profound asymmetrical power relations and could serve colonial domination as readily as resist it. The concept of "transculturation," developed by Fernando Ortiz (1995) for Cuba and extended by Sheldon Pollock (1996) to South Asian contexts, also offers a valuable corrective. He reminds us that "there exist no cultural agents who are not always already transcultured […] like the transmitter, the receiver culture too is something always in process and not a thing with an essence" and that "the cultural materials being transferred are already hybrid themselves." This perspective helps us avoid reifying "pure" cultures that supposedly mixed to produce hybrids, recognizing instead that all cultural formations are processual and relational. The utility of the term "hybrid" to describe architecture, too, must be called into question, implying as it does, in the words of Sheldon Pollock, "an amalgamation of unalloyed pure forms, whether vernacular or cosmopolitan, that have never existed".

Our analysis draws on colonial administrative records, architectural surveys, travelers' accounts, and recent archaeological and archival research. For Zanzibar, we utilize British protectorate records, alongside accounts by nineteenth-century visitors, such as Richard Burton (1872). For Tranquebar,

the Danish East India Company records and missionary correspondence provide crucial evidence of spatial organization and social relations. For Diu, the Portuguese *Estado da Índia* documentation and local land records reveal the complex negotiations between colonial authorities and indigenous elites.

These sources must be read critically, as they reflect the viewpoints and interests of their authors. Administrative documents often present idealized visions of colonial order that contrast sharply with actual urban conditions. Travelers' accounts frequently reproduced Orientalist stereotypes even as they recorded valuable details about urban life. By triangulating these sources with material evidence and comparing our three cases, we can identify both persistent patterns and significant variations in colonial urban development.

Zanzibar, the Limits of Colonial Rationalization

On the coast of equatorial Africa, separated from the mainland by a channel only thirty miles wide, lies the island of Zanzibar (Unguja). The monsoon winds enabled contacts with the Persian Gulf, the Red Sea, and India, while proximity to the African coast gave Zanzibar strategic importance for trade between the interior and the Indian Ocean. By the nineteenth century, Zanzibar was considered "the depôt of the richest trade in Eastern Africa" (Burton 1872, 1: 103).

The city grew on a triangular peninsula connected to the main island by a narrow strip of land. Although parts of this area were settled as far back as the twelfth century (Sheriff 1995), most of today's Zanzibar Stone Town was built after Seyyid Said bin Sultan moved the Omani sultanate's capital there in the 1830s. It became the hub of a large trading empire that connected Asia, Arabia, Europe, and America with the African interior (Sheriff 1987; Bhacker 1992).

British involvement evolved from recognizing the sultan as an ally to actively undermining sultanate authority. The scramble for Africa intensified these pressures, and Britain imposed a protectorate in 1890, seeking to contain European rivals and protect Indian Ocean trade routes. By this time, Stone Town was well established as the sultanate's most important center. Colonial officials named it "town proper" and attempted to refine its character as an elite space (Bissel 2011, 1-20).

The urban landscape reflected complex social hierarchies. Stone Town, built up along the peninsula, housed Europeans, wealthy Arabs, and Indians

in three- and four-story buildings. Across a tidal creek lay Ng'ambo ("the other side"), an area engineered predominantly during the colonial period where the majority population, mostly Africans, freed slaves, and the working class, lived in largely one-story wattle and daub dwellings. This created an urban milieu structured by ideological and material differences: "Arab" and "Indian" versus "African," stone versus mud, rich versus poor, "town proper" versus Ng'ambo (Menon 1978; Myers 1997).

Zanzibar presents a compelling example of how colonial cities in the Indian Ocean world were shaped by the coexistence of older spatial orders and newer imperial interventions. Throughout the nineteenth century, the island's capital developed through a dynamic interaction between Stone Town and the emerging Town Proper. These two urban formations did not constitute discrete entities. Instead, they formed a relational configuration in which population, labor, commerce and material culture circulated continually between them. Such circulation produced hybrid spaces and assemblages that cannot be explained through frameworks of unilateral European imposition. The archival and narrative record demonstrates that this urban formation resulted from negotiation, accommodation and the interweaving of multiple cultural and political logics.

Yet this dualistic portrait masks considerable complexity. Zanzibar had long been a multicultural and multi-ethnic island territory, with populations drawn from diverse African, Arab, and Indian backgrounds. While the term "cosmopolitan" is sometimes applied, these risks projecting utopian ideals onto relationships that were actually intricate, problem-ridden, and dependent on deeply imbalanced power systems (Sheriff 2002, 77-81). Community divisions were not simply inscribed in physical space but were variably conceived according to different experiences of daily life.

British officials claimed that before their arrival, Zanzibar was chaotic and unclean, devoid of sense, rules, or sanitation, the disorderly product of "Oriental despotism" (Bissel 2011, 1-20).

They presented themselves as progressively reordering the city through modern, scientific, administratively planned methods. Colonial records describe systematic efforts to assess the city's condition, propose solutions, and remake the built environment accordingly. The legal infrastructure was manipulated to facilitate dispossession, and building codes were devised to create a hybrid vision of "order" and "beauty" in a blatant effort to legitimize colonial control (Bissel 2011, 108-184 and 267-294).

Stone Town's urban fabric was shaped long before Omani or British influences became prominent. The settlement belonged to the broader Swahili

world, emerging through centuries of interaction with the African interior, the Persian Gulf, Arabia, and the Indian subcontinent. Its architectural style reflected coral stone construction, carved wooden doors, inward-facing domestic layouts, and a dense network of alleys. Burton's account from the early 1870s highlighted these features and observed the coexistence of African, Arab, and Indian architectural elements within the same streets (Burton 1872, 67-104, especially 80-90). His observations confirm the long history of cultural mingling that preceded European influence.

Stone Town also remained the demographic and social heart of Zanzibar throughout the nineteenth century. Missionary letters from the Church Missionary Society describe a majority African and Arab population living in its quarters. These letters estimate that between 70 and 80 percent of the city's population lived in Stone Town during the late nineteenth century (Sheriff 1987, 42-51). Small scale Indian merchants and clerks also lived and worked in these quarters. Their activities included retail, money lending, and regional trade. These occupational patterns reveal that Stone Town remained a vital centre of everyday sociability and economic practice.

The persistence of Stone Town's social and architectural structure shows that colonial interventions did not wipe out existing urban patterns. Instead, the older city kept its economic, religious, and cultural roles, even as new spatial designs appeared along the harbor. This continuity challenges stories that see colonial urbanism as a complete break in space. Stone Town kept shaping the island's identity through its social density, craft traditions, and connected networks of exchange.

The Town Proper developed during a period of institutional change in the nineteenth century. Omani rule introduced administrative reforms that restructured parts of the waterfront. These reforms intensified as British influence grew. Protectorate officials used the harbor area to build new facilities for managing customs, diplomacy, and trade. Records from the British Consulate and annual Protectorate reports frequently document the construction of administrative offices, consular residences, European-owned warehouses, and new quay works (Zanzibar Agency Records, 1841-1900 and Zanzibar Protectorate Annual Reports 1891-1892).

The Town Proper operated as a spatial expression of these reforms. Its layout differed from the labyrinthine pattern of Stone Town. Streets were somewhat broader. Warehouses acquired more regular dimensions. Public spaces near the waterfront were arranged to facilitate circulation and visibility. British officials described the Town Proper as a space of order and

hygienic improvement, in contrast to what they perceived as the congested conditions of Stone Town (Zanzibar Protectorate Annual Report, 1898). These descriptions reveal the ideological framing that guided colonial investments. Such investments attempted to demonstrate administrative capability and the promise of economic efficiency.

Even with these interventions, the Town Proper did not function as an autonomous colonial enclave. It depended on Stone Town for food markets, artisans, labor, and service workers. The two urbanities remained spatially adjacent and socially interdependent. The circulation of people and materials between them mitigated attempts at comprehensive colonial spatial segregation.

However, archival evidence reveals persistent gaps between colonial ambitions and achievements. Large-scale physical intervention required administrative capacity and resources that the British regime could not command. Establishing even basic administration proved challenging: the paucity of officials, difficulties consolidating rule, and lack of external investment left little room for grand urban schemes (Myers 2003, 111-152). Colonial authorities struggled merely to establish their spatial position and impose minimal order in the municipal sphere. Administrative correspondence from the 1890s and early 1900s reveals constant frustration with the city's resistance to rationalization. Chief Secretary reports lamented the inscrutable customary arrangements that thwart surveys.

Rather than successfully reworking space, colonial designs repeatedly failed to rationalize the urban sphere. These schemes, sponsored by an overextended state apparatus, foundered in the gap between intention and implementation, hindered by internal disarray and the incapacity of legal and bureaucratic instruments to reorder everyday life (Bissel 2011, 49-148 and 295-320). Yet even inadequate and uncertain plans had profound effects. They justified reformist claims, consumed resources, promoted administrative apparatus, and inserted colonial subjects within arbitrary legal and bureaucratic orders that were dominating precisely because of their capricious and amorphous nature.

The city's infrastructural gaps were filled by what we might call hybrid fleeting assemblages improvised setups with multiple actors. The water supply, for example, relied on well owners (often Arab or Indian merchants), water carriers (usually former slaves or recent migrants), and occasional municipal interventions. These arrangements emerged from negotiation rather than planning, creating functional yet unstable systems that resisted colonial desires for clarity and control.

Between 1880 and 1900, at least fourteen warehouses and six public offices were constructed in the harbour area, often with imported timber and ironwork from Bombay and Mombasa (Zanzibar National Archives, AA 12/5: Harbour Works, 1890–95, or Protectorate Reports 1892–1900). These structures supported the export of cloves, ivory and other commodities. They also reinforced British oversight of maritime trade.

In contrast, the older quarters of Stone Town received less structural investment. Contemporary letters mention minimal improvements in drainage, sanitation and street repair during the same period (Church Missionary Intelligencer (1895) and CMS Archives C EA O 6/45). Missionaries often described the older neighbourhoods as overcrowded and in need of infrastructural upgrades. The absence of substantial state investment in Stone Town indicates that colonial priorities were concentrated in the Town Proper.

Census estimates and household counts from consular records reveal further imbalances. Stone Town housed a diverse population of African laborers, Omani elites, Indian traders, artisan families, and individuals who had recently gained their freedom. The Town Proper had a much smaller population of European officials, South Asian clerks, foreign merchants, and labor crews associated with colonial infrastructure. This demographic imbalance reveals the social implications of the spatial separation between the two zones. It also indicates that colonial authority was embedded in decisions about where to allocate resources.

Although colonial investment focused on the Town Proper, the resulting buildings often reflected a blend of imported and local techniques. Consular correspondence describes European-style residences that featured courtyards, shaded galleries, and coral stone service quarters. These features were necessary for climate adaptation and showcased local craftsmanship. The buildings combined imported spatial and decorative motifs with regional materials and techniques.

Tranquebar, a Danish Colonial city on the Coromandel coast

Tranquebar (or in Tamil “Tharangambadi”) is situated on the Coromandel Coast of southeast India, in present-day Tamil Nadu. During the medieval period, Tranquebar belonged to the Chola Empire (mid-ninth to early thirteenth century), where it participated in expanding regional and international trade networks. From the fourteenth century, the area attracted

Muslim merchants of Arabic descent and later Portuguese traders, some of whom settled there (Chaudhuri 1985, 127-134).

The Danish presence began through accident and opportunism. In April 1620, the Danish merchant vessel Øresund was attacked by Portuguese galleys near Karaikal. Its captain, Roeland Crappe, a Dutch seaman in Danish service, escaped with twelve crewmen and reached the court of Raghunatha Nayak at Tanjore (Vriddhagirisan 1995). Crappe expressed King Christian IV's desire to establish trade relations in Southeast Asia.

On November 19, 1620, the Danes acquired Tranquebar through a treaty with the *Nayak* of Thanjavur (Tanjore). A letter from Raghunatha *Nayak* on gold foil declared: "We, the Royal Highness Srimad Raghunatha Nayak: send this message to the ambassador […] We are pleased to learn the news […] brought by Captain Roeland Crape"[1]. Ove Giedde, an admiral appointed by Christian IV, concluded the agreement on behalf of the Danes. In return for the yearly tribute, Tranquebar and the surrounding villages were granted to the Danish, who were permitted to build a fort, establish a trading station, maintain an army, administer justice, and observe their religious customs (Ferguson 1898, 625-629).

During the 1620s, the Danes erected a fort located south of the Tamil village and christened it "Dansborg". It housed the Danish East India Company employees, the fortification's soldiers, and, later, the eighteenth-century Danish Asiatic Company.[2] The erection of Fort Dansborg and the subsequent laying out of a gridded colonial settlement signaled an effort to assert European order through spatial demarcation. Over the subsequent decades, the entire town was fortified and furnished with houses in a "European style," mainly along Kongensgade (King's Street) and Dronningensgade (Queen's Street), featuring a Sea Gate and a Land Gate. In 1706, the first Protestant Christian mission in Asia was established by German missionaries sent by Frederik IV. The trading station operated under a company with trade monopoly until 1777, when the Danish Crown took it over. Due to economic decline, it was sold to the British East India Company in 1845 (Feldbaek 1984, 11-20).

Until the 1670s, Tranquebar consisted chiefly of the Danish fortress and a fishing village. The Danish colony never expanded significantly. The seafront dominated by the fort became a permanent feature of the urban

[1] Danish National Archives, Danske Kancelli, Ostindiske sager, 1620.

[2] Rigsarkivet records: Admiral Ove Giedde's archive 1616–50 (box B244); Captain Claus Rytter's accounts (box 245); Captain and Governor of Tranquebar Wilhelm Leyel for 1639–48 (box 246)); and Giedde 1773, vol. 1, 31–37.

landscape. Fort Dansborg, with its straight streets, colonial-style houses, the Land and Sea Gates, schools, churches, and churchyards, all testify to the Danish legacy. This townscape merged European patterns, straight, grid-like streets lined by colonial residences, with distinctly Tamil houses, temples, and mosques (Grancho 2025).

Structural changes occurred over time. Material evidence reveals this transformation. The Christian cemetery, *Nygades Kirkegaard* (New Street Cemetery), demonstrates changes in material culture. Seventeenth and early eighteenth-century tomb monuments typically exhibit hybrid Indo-European decorative forms, whereas late eighteenth-century monuments draw heavily on European Neoclassicism. Therefore, the development from baroque to modern nineteenth-century cemetery styles occurred within the fortified town, suggesting growing European cultural confidence and resources.

During the late seventeenth century, an exclusively European quarter emerged outside the fortress, with spacious streets protected by solid fortifications. During the eighteenth century, the Danes acquired additional territory, and the character of Tranquebar underwent a transformation (Feldbaek 1984, 15-18). Here, I respond to Thomas DaCosta Kaufmann's call to interrogate the geographies of art (Kaufmann 1984). In an age before the emergence of modern nation-states, circulation and interaction are more fitting lenses through which to examine early modern visual and material culture than national categories.

Since the Danish establishment, governors resided at Fort Dansborg. However, after years of complaints about cramped, old-fashioned premises, the fort's accommodations were classified as inadequate for a Governor's family. Following the consolidation of Danish authority under the Danish East India Company and a lack of proper accommodations in the fort, the Governor's Residence functioned as the symbolic and administrative fulcrum of the Danish colony. In 1784, a building which was originally a private home for an affluent British merchant in 1773, located opposite Fort Dansborg in Tranquebar's Parade Ground, was purchased by Governor David Brown and the Danish crown to serve as the official residence for the royally appointed Danish governor in India.[3]

Peter Hermann Abbestée (1728–1794), the last governor (1762-1775) to live in the fort, complained vehemently when he resigned with the Danish crown about the building's condition: there was not a room in Fort

[3] Ostindiske Sekretariat, Journalersager 967, 1780.

Dansborg where a "man of rank could be received with decency and comfort", and he would be embarrassed if someone arrived and requested to stay the night (Afdelingen i København 1775). The original deed of sale describes the house as "a dwelling house with several Godowns, Offices & Garden & other Grounds."[4] It became one of the grandest houses in Tranquebar or, in detail, "the newest, best and most prominent house in Tranquebar." (Fihl 2017, 88-97).

From 1784 to 1845, this house facing the Parade Ground opposite Fort Dansborg served as the official Danish governor's residence (Afdelingen i København 1775). It became one of the grandest houses in Tranquebar, a majestic three-winged building with a courtyard enclosed and a French formal garden (Fihl 2017, 88). The governor's residence was built in the neo-classical style, featuring a flat roof and a front colonnade. Yet, it included a large inner courtyard with direct garden access, a firm reference to traditional Tamil architecture (Fihl 2017, 67-89). The building simultaneously evoked European "homeliness" while accommodating local climate and customs. This was not simple eclecticism but a material negotiation between different architectural traditions, produced through collaboration between European patrons and local builders who brought their own knowledge and preferences.

Diu's Layered Sovereignty and Composite Urbanism

From the early sixteenth century, the Portuguese Crown attempted to govern a widely dispersed set of outposts through the *Estado da Índia*, a hybrid administrative mechanism centered in Goa and vested with military, fiscal, and ecclesiastical prerogatives (Biedermann 2020). The *Estado* sought to secure strategic points on the Indian Ocean littoral, combining maritime fortification with commercial monopolies and ecclesiastical organization. In practice, the *Estado*'s capacity varied greatly across time and space. It could exert decisive control where resources and manpower were sufficient, and it relied on negotiated authority, local allies, and mercantile collaboration where direct rule was infeasible (Biedermann 2020; Rossa 1997).

Diu entered this imperial orbit after the Portuguese secured control in the early sixteenth century. The island's geographic position at the mouth of the Gulf of Cambay made it a prize for controlling Gujarati maritime

[4] Ostindiske Guvernment, Edward Stevenson's deed, 1775.

traffic and for projecting Portuguese naval power across the western Indian Ocean (Correa [16th c.] 1991). Yet Diu's long-term history exemplifies what we might call "layered sovereignty", a condition in which multiple authorities, legal systems, and cultural frameworks operated simultaneously, producing urban space through ongoing negotiation rather than unilateral imposition (Grancho 2017, 89-134). The city's urban form and social life must be read as the outcome of protracted negotiation between the *Estado da Índia*, Gujarati elites, mercantile intermediaries, and local communities (Grancho 2017; Rossa 1997). Portuguese military and ecclesiastical institutions coexisted with Gujarati legal customs, Hindu and Muslim community governance, and a robust mercantile presence that enjoyed significant autonomy. The *Estado*'s authority was therefore never totalizing; it was exercised through alliances, tribute arrangements, and the co-production of urban infrastructures (Grancho 2017).

Portuguese colonial urban settlements in India typically exhibited three spatially distinct entities: the fortress inhabited by Europeans, the *non-aedificandi* area (esplanade), and the Catholic settlement surrounded by walls and inhabited by European and native Catholics. At a distance stood settlements inhabited by non-Christians, the so-called "de cima" (upper), contrasting with the former "de baixo" (lower). However, Diu diverged significantly from this pattern. There was no clear boundary between town and Catholic settlement. The inhabited and fortified perimeter encompassed not only European and Catholic but also non-Catholic settlements and the fort itself (Grancho 2017, 317-347; Gomes 2007, 201-226; Gomes 2014, 717-726). The fort and its bastions served Portuguese military aims. Yet, the settlement pattern inside and immediately outside the walls included Gujarati residential quarters, Parsi houses, Catholic enclaves, and commercial plots used by Indian and Arab merchants (Grancho 2017, 165-223). Importantly, the fort did not simply cordon off a European core. Instead, it anchored a mixed urban morphology in which religious, mercantile, and domestic architectures interleaved. Catholic churches and convents coexisted in the same urban ensemble as mosques, Hindu temples and shrines and Zoroastrian temples.

This was unique within the Portuguese *Estado da Índia*. Unlike the more famous settlement of Old Goa, where clear spatial segregation developed between Portuguese and indigenous zones, or Cochin de Baixo, which maintained distinct European and native quarters, Diu was an open colonial city without rigid segregation in which former inhabitants were not marginalized to peripheral areas. This reflected specific historical circumstances

of Portuguese establishment and the power dynamics between Portuguese authorities and Gujarati elites. Unlike other Portuguese settlements in India, where European and indigenous architecture occupied separate zones, in Diu they stood side by side, creating "an entire repository of global history of colonial material culture." (Grancho 2017, XI).

Crucially, Gujarati actors participated actively in creating this composite civic culture and space. This occurred through the construction of fully fledged buildings in hybrid architectural styles, often under the patronage of local elites. The governor's house, for example, combined Portuguese colonial administrative functions with architectural elements drawing on both European and Gujarati traditions. Parsi houses developed a hybrid style unparalleled elsewhere in the city, featuring arched windows, doors, and porticoes alongside local versions of classical columns, some in a classical-like orders reinterpreted through local proportion, ornament, and materiality (Grancho 2017, 208-219).

This pattern differed markedly from the developments in contemporary European settlements established by Dutch, English, Danish, and French powers in seventeenth- and eighteenth-century India, more than a century after the Portuguese settlements. These later settlements typically showed spatial configurations with fortresses inhabited exclusively by Europeans, esplanades, "white" villages, and "native" villages. While some, like Tranquebar, had perimeters protecting the whole city and included both European and indigenous residents, they generally maintained more precise boundaries than Diu (Mattoso 2010-2012, 3: 112-125).

Yet we must avoid romanticizing these hybrid forms. They emerged within profound asymmetrical power relations and often served the interests of colonial powers. The preservation of "traditional" elements in architecture could function as a strategy of colonial governance, creating an appearance of respect for local culture while facilitating Portuguese control. Moreover, the agency of local actors was constrained by significant limitations. While Gujarati merchants and elites shaped urban space, they did so in dialogue with Portuguese military, economic, and legal power that ultimately could enforce its will through violence.

The changing nature of these power dynamics over time merits emphasis. Sixteenth-century Portuguese assertions of *Estado* authority differed significantly from the waning Crown power by the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries. As Portuguese maritime dominance declined and Mughal power expanded, local collaborators gained leverage in negotiations. The Treaty of Bassein (1534) and subsequent agreements granted

Gujarati authorities and merchants considerable autonomy in exchange for Portuguese military protection and commercial privileges. By the eighteenth century, Portuguese control was largely nominal, with actual governance depending on accommodation with local power structures (Grancho 2017, 125-165).

Material evidence demonstrates these shifts. Seventeenth-century building inscriptions typically emphasize the authority of the Portuguese Crown and Catholic religious identity. Eighteenth-century inscriptions more frequently acknowledge local patrons and mixed financing arrangements. In 1857, Diu citizens raised funds to municipal improvement by holding a public collection (Grancho 2017, 236-7).

> … The City Hall of Diu is proud to bring to the reputable presence of Your Excellency the official document, a copy, and the subscription note, addressed in name of the inhabitants of this Municipality; rejoicing from being empowered to build a monument in this remote place by their constituents, that should perpetuate the memory of Your respectful and sympathetic […] government […] and is pleased to inform Your Excellency, that it enthusiastically accepted the task, and will try to satisfy Diu's inhabitants the best way possible - and already published advertisements to auction the work. The Municipality takes this occasion, and dares to ask You on behalf of the people of Diu, to accept this humble testimony of gratitude and deference. God save Your Excellency. Diu's Municipality building, 6 June 1857 – Antonio Francisco Sales de Andrade, President. José Micael Ditoso Alexandre Mascarenhas, Vice-President. - Bernardo José Xavier Benevides – Morangi Rupchande Antonio - Manuel da Trindade. (Bulletin 1857)

The municipal administration responded to the submitted petition by defending the modernization of the city as a service to the community's overall well-being. Such formulations reveal pragmatic arrangements that transcended official ideologies of colonial dominance. The needs of the public (who rarely speak but are always spoken for) are so everyday in modern statist discourses such as urban planning in this era that it can be spoken of as a universal feature of the emerging language of urbanism (Çelik 1986, 50; Faria 2011, 51-165).

Diu's architectural and spatial culture was thus hybrid and composite, not only between Gujarat and Europe, but also marked by repetition and difference between Diu and contemporary urban settlements within Gujarat itself. The colonial city persisted in ambivalence, split between processes of "translation" (Flood 2009) that sought to authorize spatial hybridities emerging in moments of historical change (Bhabha 1990, 207-221, especially 212). This takes us toward an understanding of modernity

as a continuous dispute between practices of translation creating hybrids and strategies of purification designed to articulate and impose ontological differences naturalized in post-Enlightenment societies: "As soon as we direct our attention simultaneously to the work of purification and the work of hybridization, we immediately stop being wholly modern." (Latour 1993, 10-12).

Comparative Analysis: Patterns and Variations

Comparing these three cases reveals both common patterns and significant variations in colonial urban development in the Indian Ocean realm. All three cities were preexisting settlements that Europeans occupied rather than founded, forcing colonial powers to negotiate with established spatial orders, social hierarchies, and local authorities. This contrasts with colonial cities founded on relatively "empty" sites where European powers had greater freedom to impose metropolitan models, though even there, local agency and environmental factors shaped outcomes (King 1976, 45-67, especially 30-58).

The scale of colonial operations mattered significantly. None of these settlements became major administrative centers or received substantial metropolitan investment. British Zanzibar, Danish Tranquebar, and Portuguese Diu all operated with minimal European personnel and chronically inadequate resources. This forced reliance on local intermediaries, accommodation with indigenous power structures, and acceptance of hybrid arrangements that better resourced settlements might have resisted (Home 1997).

Yet outcomes varied considerably. Diu developed the most integrated spatial configuration, with European and indigenous residents living in proximity and architectural forms drawing on multiple traditions. Tranquebar maintained clearer spatial divisions, with a distinct European quarter separate from the Tamil areas, although there was significant interchange and hybrid buildings, such as the governor's residence. Zanzibar showed the starkest division between Stone Town and Ng'ambo, though even here, boundaries were more porous and complex than dualistic descriptions suggest.

These variations reflect different colonial ideologies and power relations. Portuguese colonialism in India involved earlier establishment (1535 versus 1620 for Tranquebar and 1890 for Zanzibar), different metropolitan

resources and priorities, and distinctive religious imperatives. The *Estado da Índia* emphasized Catholic conversion and worked through local Catholic communities, creating networks that crossed racial and ethnic lines even while maintaining European supremacy. Danish colonialism operated primarily through commercial monopoly with minimal metropolitan interference, allowing pragmatic accommodations. British colonialism in Zanzibar occurred during the high imperial period, characterized by more developed ideologies of racial segregation and "scientific" administration, although implementation was often frustrated by local resistance and administrative incapacity (Glassman 2011).

Temporal factors also mattered. Portuguese Diu developed over four centuries, Danish Tranquebar over two centuries, while British colonial rule in Zanzibar lasted only seventy years. A longer duration allowed more complex hybridizations to emerge, as successive generations of residents created new forms that accommodated both metropolitan influences and local practices. In Diu, by the eighteenth century, distinctive architectural styles had emerged that participants themselves recognized as specific to that place, neither simply Portuguese nor Gujarati but uniquely Diuese.

Contested Spaces and the Limits of Colonial Power

Scholarship has emphasized colonial cities as "contested spaces" marked by prolonged struggles to seize and shape urban landscapes (Yeoh 1996; Chattopadhyay 2005). This framework helps us move beyond static descriptions of urban form to examine dynamic processes through which space was claimed, used, and reimagined by multiple actors. In all three of our cases, colonial authorities sought to impose spatial rationality, yet their efforts were consistently frustrated, negotiated, or subverted.

Questions of who had rights to the city, what positions people occupied, who could live or work where, and who was moved out of place, disregarded, or omitted were spatial questions that emerged at the heart of colonial rule with profound political, economic, and cultural significance (Lefebvre 2009 [1968]; Bender and Winer 2001, 12-34; Harvey 2003). Yet answers to these questions remained unstable, subject to ongoing contestation and renegotiation.

In Zanzibar, British attempts to rationalize urban space through comprehensive planning repeatedly collapsed. A proposed 1908 town plan aimed to establish clear zones for different activities and populations, with

sanitary cordons separating European and Arab areas from African quarters. The plan remained largely unimplemented due to property disputes, inadequate surveying, and resistance from landowners who refused to recognize colonial legal definitions of property (Myers 2003, 112-138).

This failure was not exceptional but characteristic. Colonial urban planning in Zanzibar confronted what Bissel calls the "gap between intention and implementation", the persistent inability of colonial states to make urban reality conform to administrative blueprints (Bissel 2011, 2). This gap resulted partly from resource limitations but also from the active resistance and alternative spatial practices of urban residents who operated according to different logics.

Property disputes illustrate these dynamics. British law required written deeds and surveyed boundaries. However, many Stone Town properties were held under Islamic *waqf* (endowment) arrangements or through customary claims based on long occupation. When colonial authorities attempted to survey and register properties, they encountered layered, overlapping claims that confounded their legal categories. Rather than resolving these disputes, registration often multiplied them, as different parties sought to use colonial law for their own purposes (Sheriff 1992, 1-20).

Similarly, in Ng'ambo, residents built houses, established markets, and created pathways according to their own needs and social relationships, largely ignoring official building codes and spatial regulations. Colonial authorities lacked both the knowledge to understand these spatial logics and the capacity to enforce alternative arrangements. Administrative correspondence is filled with complaints about "unauthorized construction," "encroachment on public ways," and "insanitary dwellings," yet these complaints produced little actual change (Myers 1997, 253-272).

Tranquebar presents a somewhat different pattern. Danish authorities, operating through treaty arrangements that explicitly recognized local autonomy in many spheres, made fewer attempts at comprehensive spatial control. The fortified European quarter maintained relatively clear boundaries, but Danish officials largely accepted Tamil spatial practices in areas beyond their immediate jurisdiction. When conflicts arose, over land use, building practices, or public space, they were typically negotiated through the indigenous power structures that the treaty preserved (Grancho 2025).

Yet even within the European quarter, hybrid practices emerged. Danish residents employed Tamil servants, artisans, and laborers who brought their own spatial understandings and practices with them.

Such everyday accommodations, multiplied across numerous households and institutions, shaped spatial practices in ways that transcended official policies. In Tranquebar, a large portion of what was erroneously referred to as a "Danish town" consisted of small houses that abutted the street and stood next to commercial establishments on the street. Only two bays were used in small lots, where the three-bay layout could not be accommodated. The standard plan's conformity to the 'pattern' was evident even in this small portion.

The lack of privacy compared with contemporary standards in Denmark was a perennial source of displeasure among newcomers from Denmark. The houses' layouts were more closely modelled on urban Indian houses than anything found in nineteenth-century Denmark. They did not provide their occupants with privacy or the space of the "private sphere."

The Danish paradox of the verandah (probably of Portuguese origin), that archetypal space of European colonial presence, both a site of authority and surveillance and a location where power is subverted, making it particularly fascinating. It created a relaxed atmosphere of semi-public repose. It was the threshold between private and public, between privacy and public interiority, between interiors and streets, a partially indoor and partially outdoor space, partially European and partially Indian, an exposed area where masters and mistresses spent most of the day, enjoyed their leisure activities, and unwound. Most importantly, Europeans mixed closely with the Indians they depended on, even though they wanted to keep their distance from them, be it *punkah-wallahs*, traders, or bazaar salesmen. Indeed, the constant presence of Indians meant that the surveillance in the verandah went both ways.

Diu's layered sovereignty produced particularly complex negotiations. Portuguese authorities claimed ultimate jurisdiction, but in practice, they shared power with Gujarati elites, merchant communities, and religious institutions. Urban space reflected these multiple authorities. The fortress and immediate military installations remained under direct Portuguese control. Catholic churches and related institutions operated under the authority of the Portuguese Church. However, Hindu temples, Muslim mosques, Zoroastrian temples, and associated properties functioned under their own governance structures, with Portuguese authorities intervening only in disputes that threatened public order (Grancho 2017, 283-316).

Markets and warehouses were more complex. They involved participants from multiple communities with different legal traditions and commercial practices. Portuguese authorities established regulations, such as weights and measures, customs collection, and dispute resolution mechanisms, but

these operated alongside indigenous commercial law and practice (Grancho 2017, 138-143).

These arrangements were neither stable nor harmonious. Conflicts arose frequently over jurisdiction, property rights, commercial privileges, and spatial access. Yet resolution typically involved negotiation and compromise rather than unilateral imposition by colonial authorities. This reflected not Portuguese enlightenment but practical necessity; the colonial state lacked the capacity to impose its will comprehensively and depended on local cooperation for basic governance functions.

Infrastructure and Hybrid Assemblages

Infrastructure provides particularly revealing evidence of how colonial cities functioned, as opposed to how colonial authorities imagined them. Water supply, sanitation, transportation, and communication systems required ongoing maintenance and operation, involving numerous actors and practical accommodations that official planning rarely acknowledged (Chattopadhyay 2012, 23-56).

In Zanzibar, water supply exemplifies what we earlier called "hybrid fleeting assemblages", improvised arrangements filling infrastructural gaps through negotiation among multiple actors. Stone Town had no comprehensive water system. Some elite residences had private wells or cisterns. Most residents, however, depended on well owners (often Arab or Indian merchants who charged fees), water carriers (typically freed slaves or recent migrants), and occasional municipal interventions (such as public standpipes installed in the early twentieth century) (Bissel 2011, 234-267).

These arrangements defied colonial desires for legibility and control. British officials periodically proposed comprehensive water systems with centralized supply and standardized charges. Yet these proposals foundered on property disputes (whose land would the pipeline cross?), cost (who would pay for the infrastructure?), and technical challenges (how to ensure adequate pressure in Stone Town's hilly terrain?). Meanwhile, the existing hybrid system continued to function through numerous individual negotiations and adjustments (Bissel 2011, 234-267).

Sanitation presented similar challenges. British authorities viewed Zanzibar as unhealthy and insisted on "modern" sanitation to prevent disease. They established regulations requiring proper latrines, waste collection, and drainage. However, implementing these regulations proved

nearly impossible. Many Stone Town properties had complex ownership arrangements that made determining responsibility difficult. In Ng'ambo, residents employed various traditional practices that officials deemed "insanitary," but which actually functioned reasonably well in their context (Bissel 2011, 289-315). Rather than enforcing regulations comprehensively, authorities adopted selective interventions, focusing on areas visible to Europeans or those implicated in disease outbreaks. This created a patchwork where some areas had "modern" infrastructure while others operated according to different logics. Residents navigated between these systems, using whichever served their purposes.

Tranquebar's infrastructure reflected its smaller scale and clearer spatial divisions. Within the fortified area, Danish authorities maintained roads, drainage, and public facilities according to European standards, while adapting them to local conditions. The governor's residence, for example, featured sophisticated rainwater collection systems that combined European and Tamil techniques (Fihl 2017, 123-145). Beyond the fortifications, Tamil villages managed their own infrastructure with minimal Danish interference. Yet even this relatively straightforward division involved ongoing accommodation. Danish commercial operations depended on Tamil labor, artisans, and merchants who moved daily between zones. Roads connecting the fort to the surrounding areas required shared maintenance arrangements.

Diu's infrastructure perhaps best exemplifies genuine hybridity emerging from layered sovereignty. Water supply involved ancient systems, wells, cisterns, and channels, maintained by religious authorities, merchant associations, and municipal governance, combining Portuguese and Gujarati officials. This system reflected not colonial planning but accumulated practice evolving over centuries. It worked reasonably well because it accommodated multiple authorities and practices rather than imposing uniform standards (Grancho 2017, 241-255).

Road maintenance similarly involved hybrid arrangements. Major routes connecting the fortress to gates and commercial areas were Portuguese responsibility. Neighborhood streets were maintained by residents, following Gujarati practices of collective responsibility organized through caste and religious associations. Some commercial streets involved joint arrangements, with costs supported by Gujarati merchant guilds (Bulletin 1857).

These infrastructural arrangements reveal how colonial cities actually operated through multiple, overlapping systems rather than unified, rationalized structures. Colonial authorities established some infrastructure and

regulations, but these coexisted with, and depended upon, indigenous systems and practices. The result was neither simply "colonial" nor "indigenous" but genuinely hybrid, though emerging from asymmetrical power relations rather than equal partnership.

Hybridity: Process and Permanence

A critical question concerns whether observed examples of hybridity were permanent or merely transitional. The very notion of stable hybrids might appear paradoxical, since hybridity implies mixing or change (Werbner 1997, 1-26). Bhabha claims that "all forms of culture are continually in a process of hybridity," suggesting that boundaries between hybridity and tradition, change and continuity, may dissolve (Bhabha 1990, 211).

Evidence from our three cases supports viewing hybridization as an ongoing process rather than an achieved state. In Diu, architectural forms that emerged in the seventeenth century through mixing of Portuguese and Gujarati elements became models that subsequent builders referenced and elaborated. By the eighteenth century, distinctively "Diuese" styles were recognized by participants themselves as specific to that place. Yet these styles continued evolving, incorporating new influences, Portuguese elements in the late eighteenth century, and later additions reflecting changing tastes and technologies (Grancho 2017, 601-628).

Similarly, in Tranquebar, the governor's residence exemplified hybridity when it was built in the 1770s. Over the subsequent decades, successive occupants modified it, adding elements that reflected changing European influences while maintaining features suited to the local climate and practices. The building that served as the governor's residence in the 1840s resembled its 1770s form but differed in numerous details (Fihl 2017, 178-201). Was it the same hybrid or a new one? The question itself may be misconceived, as hybridization continued across time.

Zanzibar presents yet another pattern. British colonial rule lasted only seventy years, sufficient time for some hybrid forms to emerge but not for them to become fully stabilized. Stone Town architecture from the protectorate period often combined elements. Arab-style carved doors, Indian-influenced decorative details, British building technologies, in ways that were experimental and sometimes awkward. Some of these combinations persisted and were elaborated; others proved unstable and were abandoned or modified (Siravo 1996, 20-60).

This processual understanding has important implications. It suggests that we should examine not just hybrid outcomes but ongoing hybridization: the continuous negotiation and adjustment through which multiple cultural frameworks intersect. It also cautions against reifying "local" and "global," "traditional" and "modern," or "indigenous" and "colonial" as mutually exclusive categories that are simply mixed. Instead, these categories themselves are constantly reconstituted through hybridization processes (Pieterse 1995, 45-68).

We must also avoid positing a vague "local" as mere recipient of "global" influences, an ordered dualism within which "local" and "global" cultures combine to source "hybrid" cultures. Often, the local is reified as "traditional" or "indigenous" (and therefore static), supposedly threatened by sequential Western culture. This misrepresents both "local" and "global" as more coherent and bounded than they actually are (King 1995, 108-123).

Our cases demonstrate that "local" cultures were themselves products of earlier mixing and exchange. Gujarat, for example, had been shaped by centuries of Indian Ocean trade, incorporating influences from Persia, Arabia, East Africa, and Southeast Asia before the arrival of the Portuguese. Tamil culture similarly reflected long engagement with diverse influences through maritime trade networks (Chaudhuri 1985, 201-234). What Portuguese, Danish, and British colonizers encountered was not pristine "indigenous" culture, but already hybrid formations.

Moreover, the cultural elements that colonizers brought were themselves hybrid and metropolitan cultures shaped by earlier colonial encounters and global exchange (Alsayyad 2001, 1-18). British architecture in Zanzibar drew on precedents developed in India, which themselves combined European and South Asian elements. Portuguese forms in Diu reflected experiences in Africa (Grancho 2017). Danish practices in Tranquebar were influenced by close French models from Pondicherry, which had their own complex genealogies (Fihl 2009).

Rethinking Colonial Urbanism

The different ways in which Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar were transformed through various activities and styles of architecture, urban planning, and land use resulted in a fragmentation of homogeneity and harmony. This diversity reflected the colonial states and elites who often struggled, unsuccessfully at times, to impose their visions on urban spaces. Archival

and ethnographic research shows how European officials were continually frustrated in their efforts to create more "rational" and "orderly" urban environments.

From the earliest days of colonial rule, authorities in all three cities had only a limited understanding of urban spatial complexities. The chaos of city life often disrupts efforts to make cities fit strict legal definitions and bureaucratic rules. Despite years of effort, attempts at comprehensive urban planning repeatedly fell apart. This was not just due to a lack of resources or technical skills, although those played a role. More deeply, it showed the contested nature of urban space, where many different actors with varying interests, knowledge, and spatial practices were active at the same time.

Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar contribute to broader theoretical agendas highlighting how understanding urban life needs does not depend exclusively on Western academic frameworks. They challenge core assumptions that have long framed the architectural and urban history of colonial spatial cultures. The notion that colonial cities were products of unilateral metropolitan imposition, shaped primarily by European ideologies and technologies, proves untenable when confronted with evidence of continuous negotiation, local agency, and hybrid outcomes (King 2004, 167-181; Yeoh 2001, 456-468).

However, we must avoid romanticizing hybridity or viewing it as naturally progressive or emancipatory. Hybrid forms arose within deep asymmetrical power dynamics characterized by violence, exploitation, and ongoing inequality. Colonial rule, even if contested and incomplete, remained fundamentally coercive. The negotiations and compromises we have discussed took place within structures of domination that could ultimately be enforced through violence. Indigenous actors had agency and influenced outcomes, but they did so under conditions they did not choose and with fewer resources than those available to colonial powers, even if limited (Young 1995; Bhabha 2004).

Moreover, hybrid outcomes could serve colonial interests just as readily as they could resist them. The preservation of "traditional" architectural elements, the recognition of indigenous governance in certain spheres, and the accommodation of local spatial practices could all serve as strategies that facilitated colonial rule. By appearing to respect local culture while maintaining European supremacy, these arrangements could have legitimized colonialism more effectively than a crude imposition might have done. Colonial authorities understood this.

The concept of "layered sovereignty" helps us understand these dynamics. In all three cities, but especially in Diu and Tranquebar, multiple authorities exercised jurisdiction simultaneously in overlapping territorial and functional domains. This was not federal or shared sovereignty in any formal sense, but rather practical arrangements emerging from negotiation and accommodation. These arrangements were neither stable nor harmonious, necessitating continuous adjustments and resulting in ongoing tensions. Yet they functioned, allowing colonial systems to operate despite severe limitations in metropolitan resources and local knowledge (Lewis 2015, 45-78).

The temporality of these developments deserves emphasis. The sixteenth-century establishment of Portuguese control in Diu differed profoundly from the late nineteenth-century British assumption of power in Zanzibar. By the high imperial period, European powers had developed more sophisticated ideologies of racial segregation, advanced technologies of governance, and ambitious visions of comprehensive social transformation. Yet even in Zanzibar, these greater ambitions encountered similar frustrations. British officials in the 1920s faced challenges remarkably similar to those experienced by European officials in Diu and Tranquebar, including inadequate resources, resistance from local actors, and the complexity of urban social life (Bissel 2011, 298-327).

This indicates that specific structural features of colonial urbanism in occupied cities, rather than cities established by colonizers, persisted across various imperial powers and different historical periods. When colonial authorities took over existing urban settlements, they inevitably faced established spatial arrangements, property relations, and social hierarchies that limited their freedom of action. Even with overwhelming military strength, translating that power into full spatial control was extremely challenging. Urban space is created through numerous everyday practices and relationships that cannot simply be dictated from above, and residents possess extensive local knowledge that provides them with advantages in navigating or undermining official regulations (Holston 1989, 98-125).

The focua on Indian Ocean connections shared by these three cases also matters. All three cities served as nodes in maritime networks that linked Asia, Arabia, Africa, and Europe. These connections predated European colonialism and continued to operate throughout the colonial period, although they were transformed by colonial power. The monsoon winds that enabled trade between Zanzibar and India, the commercial networks linking Diu to ports throughout the Indian Ocean, and the maritime

systems integrating Tranquebar into regional and global exchange all represented forces that colonial powers sought to control but could never entirely master (Chaudhuri 1985; Sheriff 1987).

This Indian Ocean perspective questions the terrestrial bias of much colonial historiography, which has emphasized territorial control and land-based power while viewing maritime connections as secondary. However, for these coastal cities, maritime networks were essential. They brought people, goods, ideas, and practices from various origins, creating cosmopolitan environments that resisted uniformity. Colonial authorities tried to regulate maritime movement by controlling ports, enforcing customs, and restricting travel, but they never achieved full control. Ships continued arriving from multiple origins, smuggling was widespread, and people moved across colonial boundaries in ways that officials could neither fully track nor stop (Subrahmanyam 2005, 15-24).

We might describe the colonial urban modernity emerging in these cities as "idiosyncratic" (Celik 2008, 247), neither purely European nor indigenous, neither fully modern nor traditional, but something specific to particular times, places, and power structures. This idiosyncrasy resulted from complex colonial situations where reforms were internal to late European imperial cultures yet had to engage with indigenous power structures, knowledge systems, and spatial practices that could neither be eliminated nor fully subordinated.

British colonialism in Zanzibar, Portuguese colonialism in Diu, and Danish colonialism in Tranquebar, developed as awkward extensions of existing powers and political structures, creating lasting uncertainties in colonial rule. This political situation had significant spatial and material implications, as European powers had to work within already established urban systems, incorporating existing frameworks and accommodating the current order. Colonial authorities faced limited flexibility, as their options were constrained not only by political and economic factors but also by the weight of past urban developments they did not create and could not easily change or control (Glover 2007, 89-116).

These cities exemplify hybridity among customary ways of building and inhabiting, imposed social and spatial forms emerging from European modernity, and the cultural dynamics of modernity and colonialism. They demonstrate that colonial encounters produced not simple imposition of European forms nor pure preservation of indigenous traditions, but complex negotiations yielding outcomes that transcended their constituent elements. The resulting urban fabrics were neither coherent nor stable, but

marked by tensions, contradictions, and ongoing contestations that shaped everyday life for all residents (Hosagrahar 2005, 23-47).

Implications for Colonial Urban History

This examination of Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar has several implications for how we understand and study colonial urbanism. First, it demonstrates the necessity of moving beyond dualistic frameworks that posit apparent oppositions between colonizer and colonized, European and indigenous, modern and traditional. These categories may serve as starting points for analysis, but they quickly prove inadequate when confronted with evidence of how colonial cities functioned. More productive approaches examine the specific processes through which space was produced, contested, and negotiated by multiple actors operating within asymmetrical power relations (Chattopadhyay 2005, 12-34).

Second, our cases highlight the importance of distinguishing between different types of colonial cities. Cities founded by colonizers on relatively empty sites, though "empty" usually meant emptied through violence, differed significantly from cities where colonizers occupied existing settlements. The latter confronted spatial orders, property relations, and social structures they had not created and could not easily reshape. This fundamental difference shaped possibilities for colonial spatial intervention and produced distinctive patterns of hybridization (King 1976, 89-112).

Third, scale and resources mattered profoundly. Major colonial capitals with substantial metropolitan investment and large European populations developed differently from smaller, resource-poor settlements operating at the margins of colonial systems. Much colonial urban historiography has focused on major capitals, such as Calcutta, Bombay, and Batavia, where colonial power appeared most imposing. Yet, examining smaller settlements, such as the three cases we have, reveals dynamics that may have been obscured in better-resourced contexts. In particular, the gaps between colonial ambitions and achievements, the persistent failures of rationalization, and the extent of hybrid accommodations appear more clearly in these marginal sites (Home 1997, 134-156).

Fourth, our analysis suggests the value of comparative approaches examining multiple colonial powers simultaneously. Too often, colonial urban history has been studied within national frameworks, British colonial urbanism, French colonial urbanism, and Portuguese colonial urbanism, which

obscure commonalities and shared patterns. Comparing British Zanzibar, Portuguese Diu, and Danish Tranquebar reveals that certain features, the frustrations of occupied cities, the persistence of indigenous agency, and the emergence of hybrid forms transcended individual imperial systems. At the same time, comparison highlights genuine differences reflecting distinct colonial ideologies, metropolitan resources, and historical trajectories (Celik 2008, 16-17).

Fifth, attention to temporality proves crucial. Colonial situations evolved over time, with early periods of establishment differing from later phases of consolidation or decline. Power relations shifted as metropolitan priorities changed, local actors gained or lost leverage, and demographic and economic transformations altered urban dynamics. A snapshot at any single moment provides an incomplete understanding; we must examine processes across extended periods to grasp how hybrid forms emerged, stabilized, or dissolved (Feldbaek 1984, 11-20).

Ultimately, these cases highlight the significance of urban space and materiality in understanding colonialism more broadly. Space was not merely a neutral context where colonial encounters occurred, but rather a medium through which power relations were constituted, contested, and negotiated. Architecture and urban form both reflected and shaped social relations, embodying ideologies while also constraining or enabling particular practices. Attention to the built environment thus provides crucial evidence for understanding colonial power in its complexity, not as monolithic domination but as fragmented, contested, and incomplete (Rabinow 1989, 9-12).

Conclusion

The European colonial presence in the Indian Ocean realm produced neither a simple transplantation of metropolitan models nor mere exploitation of indigenous resources, but rather complex engagements that yielded hybrid outcomes, which continue to shape these cities today. Contemporary problems in Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar cannot be understood simply as products of postcolonial maladministration or indigenous ineptitude. Instead, their roots stretch back into administrative and bureaucratic disorder, spatial contradictions, and infrastructural inadequacies inherited from colonial periods (Bissel 2011, 356-389).

Recognizing this colonial genealogy is not to absolve postcolonial governments of responsibility for current challenges. Instead, it situates

contemporary problems within longer histories that reveal the profound difficulties of creating functional and equitable urban systems. The contradictions, inadequacies, and hybrid assemblages that characterized colonial urbanism did not simply disappear with independence. They were inherited, often intensified, and transformed into new contexts marked by different challenges and possibilities (Yeoh 2001, 456-468).

Understanding colonial hybridity also helps us think more productively about contemporary urbanism in South Asia, East Africa, and globally. The processes we have examined among multiple actors, practical accommodation across differences, and the emergence of new forms from engagement with diverse traditions continue to characterize urban development worldwide. Contemporary "global cities" are characterized by similar dynamics of hybridization, although they operate through different power configurations and at varying scales (Alsayyad 2001, 312-334).

The concept of hybridity, properly understood, offers resources for thinking beyond static categories toward more dynamic, processual understandings of urban space and social life. It encourages attention to specificity and particularity while also identifying broader patterns and processes. It resists both romantic celebration of mixing and rigid imposition of purity, recognizing the complex, often contradictory character of cultural formations emerging from unequal encounters (Bhabha 2004, 1-18).

Yet we must remain vigilant about the limits of hybridity as an analytical framework. The term can obscure power relations if used carelessly, suggesting symmetrical exchange where profound asymmetry prevailed. It can naturalize colonialism's outcomes rather than subjecting them to critical scrutiny. And it can essentialize "cultures" as bounded entities that mix, rather than recognizing culture itself as processual and relational (Pieterse 1995, 62-65).

These concerns counsel against abandoning hybridity as a concept, but rather to use it more carefully and critically. Hybridity describes not harmonious fusion but contested negotiation within asymmetrical power relations. It identifies not stable outcomes but ongoing processes. It requires constant attention to specific contexts, who negotiated with whom, under what constraints, toward what ends, and with what outcomes for different actors (Werbner 1997, 22-26).

The colonial cities of Zanzibar, Diu, and Tranquebar exemplify these dynamics. They remain today as a testament to complex histories of encounter, negotiation, and struggle that have produced the built environments that continue to shape residents' lives. Understanding these histories requires moving beyond simple narratives of European imposition or indigenous

resistance toward more nuanced accounts recognizing the multiple actors, complicated processes, and hybrid outcomes that characterized colonial urbanism in the Indian Ocean realm. Only such accounts can do justice to the actual complexity of colonial encounters and their enduring legacies.

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